Jude 12–16 — Leader / Learner Guide

Portraits of Apostasy: What False Teachers Look Like · Study 4 of 6 · Source: The Gospel Vault

Big Idea and Context

> **Big idea:** Jude teaches his readers to recognize false teachers by what they fail to produce and by the dispositions of their hearts — and reminds them that God's verdict on this pattern was announced at the beginning.

After the warnings of history (vv. 5–11), Jude paints portraits. Five pictures, one ancient prophecy, one heart portrait.

- **vv. 12–13:** hidden reefs, clouds, trees, waves, stars.
- **vv. 14–15:** Enoch's prophecy.
- **v. 16:** the heart: grumbling, lust, arrogance, flattery.

Five Pictures and One Portrait

Verse	What it says	Teaching point
v. 12	hidden reefs · waterless clouds · uprooted trees	Danger at the table; promise without substance; no fruit, no future.
v. 13	wild waves · wandering stars	Disorder produces shame; false guides end in darkness that is kept for them.
v. 14–15	Enoch	Quoted from 1 Enoch 1:9. The ungodly judged from the start.
v. 16	grumblers, fault-finders, arrogant flatterers	Chronic dissatisfaction; self-direction; self-serving speech.

Fruit and teachers: The fruit question tests teachers (Matt. 7:15–20). It is not used here to decide who is saved. Free Grace separates the two; Lordship writers often join them.

Teaching Flow

1. **Five pictures (vv. 12–13).** Work through them as a set: what is each picture's particular failure?
2. **Enoch (vv. 14–15).** The quotation and the repeated "ungodly."
3. **The portrait (v. 16).** Grumbling echoes the wilderness (v. 5).

Clarify While Teaching

- **1 Enoch:** Jude quotes it for what it says. It does not make the book Scripture (compare Acts 17:28).
- **"Doubly dead":** emphatic lifelessness; not a ruling on anyone's salvation.
- **"Caring for themselves":** literally shepherding themselves; see Ezek. 34.
- **"Has been kept" (v. 13):** the same root as vv. 1, 6, 21.

Discussion and Close

1. Which picture best describes a teaching pattern you have seen?
2. How is testing a teacher by fruit different from testing a person's salvation?
3. Which of the four dispositions in v. 16 is hardest to notice in yourself?

Close: Point ahead to vv. 17–23: after portraits comes prescription. "But you, beloved…"